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A Leading Power: Shaping the International Order

Background: Global Misgovernance

A consistent challenge in international relations has involved efforts at governing the world. International politics has always been fundamentally different from national politics, in that it is characterized by ‘anarchy’ or the absence of an overarching ruler or government. Ancient literature reflects ideals that governed the rules of war and peace between sovereign entities, whether in the Iliad in Greece, the Mahabharata in India, or in literature from the Warring States Period in China. Large empires such as the Persians, Romans, and Mongols made efforts at establishing normative standards among their multicultural subjects and in their peripheries. Some cultures even attempted to derive power and legitimacy from a religious figure, such as the Pope in Western Christendom, the caliph in the Islamic world, or the ‘Son of Heaven’ under successive Chinese dynasties.

In practice, however, governance on a global scale was only seriously attempted by the colonial European powers after their imperial projects extended to the Americas, Asia, and Africa. The Congress of Vienna after the Napoleonic Wars, the Berlin Conference of 1884–85, the League of Nations after World War I, and the Washington Naval Conference of 1921–22 represented various attempts by the great powers to manage international conflict through a balance of power, colonial-era agreements, institution-building, and arms control. Although initially led by Western European colonial powers, they eventually involved others such as Russia, the United States, and Japan. But much of the rest of the world—including India—was systematically excluded. [1]